

PIKE AND MATCHLOCK MUSKET

THE BATTLE OF WHITE MOUNTAIN

In the Thirty Years' War, fought in central Europe between 1618 and 1648, all armies used infantry armed with pikes and matchlock muskets. This distinctive form of warfare is exemplified by the Battle of White Mountain, an important encounter in the opening phase of the conflict.

The Battle of White Mountain was fought outside Prague on 8 November 1620, when Bohemian Protestants, rebelling against the authority of the Holy Roman Emperor, were confronted by a mix of Catholic Imperial forces. Both armies numbered between 20,000 and 30,000 men – quite substantial amounts by the standard of the time. Commanded by Christian of Anhalt, the Bohemian Protestants had taken an advantageous defensive position on high ground, but the Catholics, led by Johann Tserclaes, Count von Tilly, were more experienced and enjoyed superior morale.

PIKE SQUARES

On both sides the pikemen formed up in tightly packed squares, a practice that had been commonplace in European warfare for over a century. The smaller number of infantry equipped with firearms – predominantly matchlock muskets – were either positioned in a “sleeve” around the outside of the pike square, or formed into squads known as “horns” at the four corners of each square. Influenced by recent tactical developments initiated by the Dutch, the Protestants deployed their pikemen in shallower squares than the Catholics, with fewer lines from front to back. Like the infantry, the cavalry were deployed in tight formations. Each rider carried several wheellock pistols, pre-loaded in preparation for the battle. Their armour was less extensive and elaborate than that of a medieval knight, but the steel plate provided some protection, even against musket balls.

A SHORT ENGAGEMENT

The Protestants were first to take the offensive. The squares of pikemen advanced down the hill, directed by sergeants marching at the flanks with their halberds. Lowering their long, unwieldy weapons, the pikemen intended to engage the enemy infantry at close quarters with a “push of pike”. The cavalry also came forward, riding knee-to-knee at a steady jog rather than a gallop. Following the established tactics of the time, each body of horsemen advanced towards an enemy pike square and discharged their pistols in a volley at as close a range as possible before turning away.

Count von Tilly, however, was confident in the quality of his troops and not inclined to stand on the defensive. He ordered his own cavalry and infantry aggressively up the slope. The Protestant musket troops were trained to fire in rolling volleys – the front row fired, then moved to the back to reload while the second row fired, and so on – to compensate for the slowness of reloading the matchlock, theoretically allowing a continuous fire to be maintained. But the Catholic squares advanced relentlessly forward through the thickening fog of gunpowder smoke, and their cavalry drove the Protestant horsemen into flight.

Unable to sustain an unsupported encounter with determined Catholic pikemen and pistol-armed cavalry at close range, the Protestants' pike squares began to break up and the pikemen were swiftly routed, fleeing for their lives. Almost 5,000 men were killed in the battle – a victory for the Catholics that was completed in less than two hours.

